

Gen Z Athletic Trends 2026

Annual report on how young consumers buy, judge and talk about athletic apparel and footwear - second edition

Cobalt Insight Partners - Consumer Practice

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Fictional data created for the MarketSignal demo.

1. Executive summary

The second edition of Gen Z Athletic Trends tracks the same cohort and the same core measures as the first, but on a larger and more representative panel. The headline is that the cohort is bigger, more digital and more selective than our first read suggested. Shoppers are buying more through social platforms, they are weighing fewer brands before they commit, and they are less swayed by sustainability messaging than a year ago, while rating speed and peer evidence higher than before.

Readers who followed the 2025 edition will notice that several published figures have moved. Some of that movement reflects real change in behavior, and some reflects the improved reach of the panel. Section 3 explains which is which and how to read the two editions together. For decision making, we recommend using the 2026 values wherever the two editions overlap and treating the earlier values as superseded.

2. Methodology

The 2026 edition draws on an online panel of US consumers aged 16 to 27, fielded across five weeks in June and July 2026. Fieldwork followed the same screening rule as before, requiring at least one athletic purchase in the previous twelve months, and results were weighted to census margins for age band, gender, region and household income. After quality checks the usable sample was 5,400 respondents, a substantial increase on the prior year.

Purchase channel questions again refer to the most recent purchase in each category, and attitude questions again report the top two boxes of a five point scale. New to this edition is a structured module on delivery expectations and on sources of trust, both of which were only touched on in qualitative form last year. Market sizing continues to combine panel spend data with reported category revenue and a modeled cohort share.

As before, the panel leans toward heavier internet users, and the sizing model carries a wider error band than the survey percentages. We have reduced, but not eliminated, the digital skew by recruiting through additional offline and community sources.

3. What changed since the 2025 edition

Two things changed between editions. The first is method. The panel was expanded, with much more coverage of respondents aged 16 to 19, of smaller metropolitan areas and of households in the lower half of the income range. These groups were thin in the first edition, and their under representation

affected both the survey percentages and the sizing model. We rebuilt the weights using the larger sample and reran the sizing model on the same basis.

The second is behavior. Between the two fieldwork periods, social platforms continued to add shopping features, the cohort aged by a year, and economic conditions tightened for younger households. We cannot cleanly separate method effects from behavioral effects for every measure, so we have not published a bridge between the editions, and we recommend against subtracting one edition from the other to describe a trend.

In practice, this means that a reader building a plan should take the current values for every measure covered in both editions, should avoid mixing figures from the two reports in a single chart, and should treat any apparent year on year change as indicative only. Where a reader needs a consistent time series, our data team can provide the 2025 respondent level data reweighted to the expanded design, which gives a like for like comparison on the revised basis.

Several figures from the 2025 edition were revised as a result. The social commerce measure, the market size estimate for 2025, the sustainability measure and the consideration set measure were all restated in this report, and each of the revised values sits in the relevant section below. The earlier editions should be regarded as superseded for these measures. The new delivery and trust measures have no earlier counterpart.

4. Social commerce

Social commerce platforms now account for 26% of Gen Z athletic footwear purchases, according to our 2026 panel. The gain is visible in every region and every age band, though it is steepest among younger members of the cohort and among those who follow creators in sport and fitness. Shoppers who buy through social platforms describe a short path from discovery to purchase, with the video acting as a try on and the comment thread acting as a size guide.

Marketplaces and brand sites remain important, and many social buyers compare options across all three before completing an order. What has changed is that the social route is no longer an experiment. Brands that treat it as a promotional channel only, with limited service cover and slow answers to questions in comments, are losing shoppers who judge them by how they behave in public.

Platform features have also changed the experience. Live shopping events, saved lists and in feed size advice have shortened the path from curiosity to checkout, and respondents described the process as closer to shopping with friends than to browsing a catalog. Shoppers in the smaller metropolitan areas that our larger panel now captures were among the keenest adopters, in part because social platforms give them access to brands that are not stocked in their local stores.

5. Market size

Using the expanded 2026 panel, we restate the 2025 US Gen Z athletic apparel market at \$44.8 billion. The restatement reflects the better coverage of younger and lower income households and the improved modeling of how much of each apparel category is bought by the cohort. It is a change in our estimate and should not be read as the market having grown overnight.

Going forward, we expect the cohort's spend to keep rising faster than the category as a whole, driven by the entry of new buyers rather than higher spend per person. The sizing covers apparel only; our footwear annex has been rebuilt on the same expanded basis and is available to subscribers.

6. Sustainability and brand choice

The share of Gen Z respondents who say sustainability claims sway their brand choice has fallen to 54%. Shoppers have not stopped caring. In open responses they described a growing fatigue with generic green messaging and a stronger preference for proof, such as origin, repair options and take back schemes. Price and fit now come first in most trade offs, and sustainability tends to act as a tie breaker between products that are otherwise comparable.

The effect varies by segment. Respondents who describe themselves as regular outdoor participants and those in higher income households still give sustainability substantial weight. Among shoppers whose budgets are tight, it ranks well below price, delivery and fit. For brands, the safest approach is to make fewer claims and to document each one.

Respondents also drew a line between environmental claims about a product and claims about how a company behaves. Product claims, such as recycled content, were judged on whether they could be seen on the label or hang tag. Corporate commitments were judged on whether the brand published progress against them. Where neither was available, shoppers said they defaulted to ignoring the message and deciding on other grounds.

7. Brand consideration

The average Gen Z shopper now weighs 3.6 athletic brands before buying. A narrower shortlist increases the importance of being on it. Entry is driven by peer exposure, by prior ownership and by visible social proof, and exit is driven by a single bad signal: an inconsistent size chart, a run of poor reviews or a delivery promise that is not kept. Value brands were again the most likely to be added in the final stage of the process.

Differences between segments are worth noting. Team and club athletes build the smallest shortlists, and often default to a single trusted label, while shoppers who buy mainly for studio classes and everyday wear explore more widely and are more willing to try a new name that a creator has recommended. Price led shoppers build shortlists around a price ceiling first and a brand second, and they are the group most likely to switch when a promotion appears.

8. Delivery and trust

Delivery within three days was rated essential by 48% of Gen Z respondents, up sharply among those buying through social platforms. Shoppers explained that speed matters most for everyday items that they need for a routine, and least for gifts or special items where they expect a wait. Delivery promises that were missed were a common source of cancelled orders, and shoppers who had a bad delivery experience told us they were more likely to remember it when building their next shortlist.

57% of Gen Z respondents said they trust peer reviews and creator try on videos more than brand advertising. Respondents described checking several reviews and at least one video of the product on a real person before purchase. Advertising was seen as a prompt to look, not a reason to buy. Reviews that mention fit, sizing across categories and durability after several weeks of wear were rated the most useful, and shoppers noticed when a brand removed or hid critical reviews.

Taken together, the two measures point to a shopper who is impatient with promises and relies on evidence. A brand that answers questions quickly, shows its delivery dates, and allows honest reviews to stand is building trust in the way that this cohort values. A brand that does the opposite risks being filtered out before the sale, and the effect is hard to see in conversion data because it occurs earlier in the journey.

9. Other trends

9.1 Fit and sizing

Fit inconsistency remains the most common complaint in our open ended data. Shoppers who wear different sizes across product categories from the same brand told us that they now treat every purchase as an experiment, and they value brands that offer a clear exchange promise and sizing guidance that is based on real garment measurements.

9.2 Durability

Expectations for durability have risen with price. Knit uppers drew the most complaints, with respondents reporting fraying at flex points within a few months of regular use. Shoppers are willing to pay more for materials they believe will last, provided that the claim is supported by reviews from people who have worn the product for some time.

9.3 Community discovery

Run clubs, campus teams, studio classes and group chats continue to be the most trusted discovery routes. We see growing interest in brands that equip instructors and community leaders, and in the use of group buying and shared wish lists inside messaging apps.

9.4 Personalization

Interest in personalization is real but conditional. Respondents were most attracted to features that improve fit, were mildly interested in color choices and showed less enthusiasm for name or initials, and they were quick to point out that a long wait would cancel the appeal. Readers interested in how much shoppers will pay should consult dedicated pricing research rather than this report.

10. Implications for brands

- Staff social channels as a core sales and service route, with response times that match the pace of the platform.
- Use the restated market size and the expanded panel as the basis for planning, and retire the figures from the previous edition.

- Keep sustainability claims few and evidenced, and put origin and material facts where shoppers look for them.
- Win a place on the shortlist through community and creator presence, and protect it by keeping size guidance and delivery promises reliable.
- Publish reviews openly, since shoppers increasingly rely on peers and creators to judge fit and durability.

11. Outlook

We expect the cohort to keep gaining weight in athletic spending, and we expect the shift toward social and marketplace routes to continue. The 2027 edition will keep the expanded panel design so that the series is comparable going forward. We welcome feedback on the new modules and on the topics you would like us to add next year, which can be sent to the Consumer Practice team at Cobalt Insight Partners.